My plan was to casually saunter to the toilets, put my head deep into the bowl and pull the chain as I puked, thus cunningly disguising any sound effects. My plan worked, and one stealthpuke later, I casually sauntered back to the changing room and put my boots on. Only my stomach wasn't *quite* finished expelling the previous night's festivities. I could feel another movement on its way, and I couldn't execute the toilet action again – the guys would definitely smell a rat. I had no choice but to guts it out – so to speak – until it was time to go on to the field. I could then hang back and dive into the toilets.

As the last person walked out of the dressing room, I darted into the toilet and puked again. (I'm feeling queasy just remembering it.)

I eventually made my way on to the field feeling slightly less nauseous, but I was still bladdy buggered. We started the warm-up with a lengthy set of stretches. Lying there on my back on the soft Adelaide turf, the sun gently warming me, was exactly what my body craved … and I promptly fell asleep.

One minute I was doing a stretch, and the next thing I knew our trainer, Paddy Upton, was tapping me on the shoulder to wake me up. The guys thought this was hilarious. During the game of touch afterwards I remember standing on the wing and somebody passing me the ball – the softest of passes – and me just missing it completely.

After that we had a net practice. South African legend Graeme Pollock was accompanying us for part of that tour to help the batters. The thing with the Adelaide practice area is that spectators can sit right behind the nets. They therefore have a clear view of how well – or, in my case that day, how poorly – batsmen are batting. I was shitting myself, thinking, 'You're in the kak here today, Hersch. You're about to face your own teammates *and* a bunch of unknown net bowlers who are no doubt dead keen on knocking you over, and you can't even see straight.'

I had a few throw-downs and then my net session proper started. On the way in I had a word with Proteas fast bowler and all-round loose cannon Mornantau 'Nantie' Hayward.

'Nantie, fucking bounce me today in the nets and I'm going to fucking whack you with this bat.' He just laughed. And shrugged. Which Nantie does a lot. He knew I was hung-over, and of course he bounced me, but I managed to just duck under one of the three balls I could actually see.